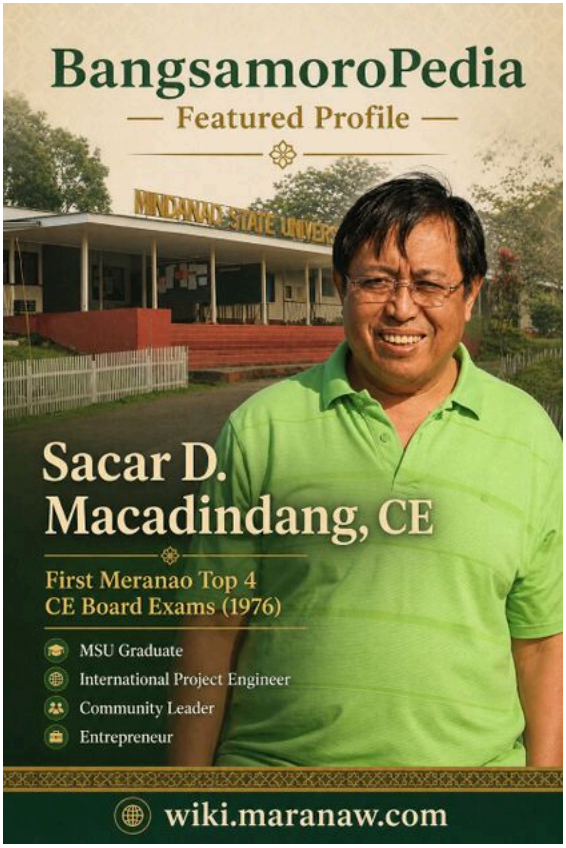
Sacar D. Macadindang

Sacar D. Macadindang is a Filipino civil engineer, entrepreneur, and community leader who made history in 1976 as the **first Muslim Meranao to rank in the top four** of the Civil Engineering Board Examination in the Philippines. A trailblazer who opened doors for succeeding generations of Mindanao Muslim engineers, Macadindang built a distinguished career spanning four decades across the Philippines and Saudi Arabia, becoming a respected figure in both structural engineering and Islamic community development. His journey from Mindanao State University to international construction projects represents the aspirations and capabilities of Bangsamoro professionals in nation-building and global infrastructure development.

Sacar D. Macadindang



Nationality	Filipino
Ethnicity	Meranao
Occupation	Civil Engineer Entrepreneur Project Management Consultant
Known for	First Muslim Meranao to rank in the top 4 of the Civil Engineering Board Exam (1976)
Education	BS Civil Engineering Mindanao State University
Notable work	Founder, Insan Islamic Assembly, Inc. Project Engineer for Toyota and Lexus facilities in Saudi Arabia
Years active	1976–present

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Background

Sacar D. Macadindang hails from the Meranao people, one of the largest Muslim ethnolinguistic groups in the Philippines, predominantly residing in the provinces surrounding Lake Lanao in Mindanao. Growing up in a region where educational and professional opportunities for Muslims were historically limited, Macadindang pursued engineering at a time when Filipino Muslims were vastly underrepresented in technical and professional fields. His decision to study civil engineering during the 1970s, a period marked by social and political challenges in Mindanao, demonstrated both personal determination and family support for higher education.

The Meranao community has a rich tradition of craftsmanship and architectural heritage, evident in their intricate woodcarving and the iconic torogan traditional houses. Macadindang's choice of civil engineering can be seen as a modern extension of this cultural legacy, translating indigenous design sensibilities into contemporary structural

practice. His achievement in 1976 would become a landmark moment for Meranao representation in the Philippine engineering profession.

Education

Macadindang earned his Bachelor of Science in Civil Engineering from Mindanao State University (MSU), the premier institution of higher learning in Muslim Mindanao. Founded in 1961, MSU was established specifically to provide educational opportunities for Filipino Muslims and other cultural communities in Mindanao, making it the natural choice for aspiring Meranao professionals.

His academic journey culminated in a historic achievement during the May 1976 Civil Engineering Board Examination. Ranking **fourth overall** in the nationwide licensure exam, Macadindang became the **first Muslim Meranao** to place in the top tier of the highly competitive test. This breakthrough was particularly significant given the systemic barriers faced by Muslim students from Mindanao, including limited access to review centers, financial constraints, and the linguistic challenge of taking exams primarily designed for Tagalog and English speakers.

The 1976 board exam result shattered prevailing stereotypes about the capabilities of Muslim engineers and served as a powerful statement about MSU's educational quality. Macadindang's achievement inspired a generation of Meranao and Maguindanao students to pursue engineering and other technical fields, contributing to the gradual diversification of the Philippine engineering profession.

Career

Early Professional Work in the Philippines

After passing the board exam, Macadindang began his career as a Research Aide at Mindanao State University, his alma mater. This position allowed him to contribute to the academic institution that had shaped his professional foundation while gaining practical experience in engineering research and applications.

He subsequently joined the National Irrigation Administration (NIA), where he applied his civil engineering expertise to agricultural infrastructure projects critical to Mindanao's farming communities. His work at NIA involved the design and construction of irrigation systems that directly impacted food security and rural development in the region.

Macadindang then moved to the private sector, working as a Civil Engineer at Erectors Inc., Philippines, a construction company where he gained experience in commercial and industrial projects. This phase of his career provided exposure to diverse construction methodologies and project management practices that would prove invaluable in his later international work.

Overseas Career in Saudi Arabia

In 1982, Macadindang joined the wave of Filipino Overseas Filipino Workers (OFWs) seeking opportunities in the Middle East. His decision to work abroad came during a period of massive infrastructure development in Saudi Arabia, driven by oil wealth and rapid urbanization. As a licensed civil engineer with proven credentials, he was well-positioned to contribute to the Kingdom's construction boom.

His Saudi Arabian career spanned multiple phases and companies, demonstrating progressive professional growth:

He began as a Junior Civil Engineer at a construction company in Jeddah, steadily advancing to senior positions as he proved his technical competence and project management capabilities. His work involved the construction of commercial buildings, residential complexes, and infrastructure projects in one of Saudi Arabia's fastest-growing cities.

Macadindang then served as Senior Cost Engineer at Kara Establishment, a role that required sophisticated understanding of construction economics, budgeting, and resource allocation. This position expanded his skill set beyond pure structural engineering into the financial and managerial aspects of large-scale construction.

His career reached a significant milestone when he became Technical Services Department Manager and Project Engineer at SAMACO (Saudi Arabian Marketing Company), where he worked for seven years. In this role, Macadindang oversaw the construction of multiple multi-story buildings serving as showrooms, offices, and hotels. The scale and complexity of these projects required coordination of diverse engineering disciplines and management of substantial construction teams.

Perhaps the most prominent phase of his overseas career was his six-year tenure as Technical Manager and Project Engineer at Abdul Latif Jameel Co., Ltd., one of Saudi Arabia's largest and most prestigious conglomerates. Macadindang's primary responsibility was the design and construction of automotive showrooms and service centers for Toyota and Lexus, two of the world's leading car brands. These projects demanded exceptional attention to detail, as automotive showrooms require specific spatial configurations, lighting systems, and structural supports for vehicle displays. His work contributed to the expansion of Japanese automotive presence in the Saudi market.

His final position before retirement was as Project Management Consultant at Dr. Fuoad Ghazali & Arch. Adel Moemen Engineering Consultant, where he worked for seven years on continued automotive showroom projects for Abdul Latif Jameel. This consultancy role represented the pinnacle of his professional career, drawing on decades of accumulated expertise in project management, cost engineering, and technical oversight.

Throughout his two decades in Saudi Arabia, Macadindang not only built buildings but also built bridges between Filipino engineering professionals and Middle Eastern employers, establishing a reputation for competence and reliability that benefited other OFWs who followed.

Return to the Philippines

After retiring from his consultancy work in Saudi Arabia, Macadindang returned to the Philippines, bringing with him decades of international experience and technical knowledge. Rather than settling into full retirement, he remained professionally active in multiple capacities.

Currently, he works as a supervising engineer for several private commercial building projects in the Philippines. This role allows him to mentor younger engineers while applying the sophisticated project management techniques he mastered during his Saudi Arabian career to Philippine construction contexts.

Entrepreneurship

Demonstrating the entrepreneurial spirit common among successful OFWs, Macadindang established **Happy Family Hardware**, a business that serves the construction industry by providing building materials and supplies. The enterprise represents a strategic application of his engineering knowledge to the commercial sector, as his technical expertise allows him to advise customers on appropriate materials and construction solutions.

Happy Family Hardware also serves as a tangible legacy for his family, creating employment opportunities and contributing to the local economy. The business name reflects Meranao cultural values that prioritize family cohesion and collective prosperity.

Institutional Contributions

Beyond his engineering career, Macadindang has been deeply involved in Islamic community development. He is one of the four founding members of the **Insan Islamic Assembly, Inc.**, an organization dedicated to religious education, community service, and the strengthening of Islamic identity among Filipino Muslims.

The Insan Islamic Assembly represents Macadindang's commitment to giving back to the Meranao community and ensuring that future generations maintain strong connections to their faith and cultural heritage. As a founder, he helped establish the organization's vision, governance structure, and programmatic priorities. His involvement reflects a holistic understanding of Muslim community needs that extends beyond economic development to include spiritual and cultural dimensions.

The organization's work is particularly important in contexts where Muslim communities face marginalization or stereotyping, providing spaces for religious practice, Islamic education, and community solidarity. Macadindang's dual identity as a successful engineer and religious community leader demonstrates that professional achievement and Islamic faith are mutually reinforcing rather than contradictory.

Legacy and Impact

Macadindang's most enduring legacy is his role as a pathbreaker for Muslim Meranao engineers. His 1976 board exam achievement demonstrated that students from Muslim Mindanao could compete at the highest levels of the Philippine engineering profession when given access to quality education. The psychological impact of this achievement cannot be overstated, as it challenged deficit narratives about Muslim intellectual capacity and inspired countless young Meranao to pursue technical education.

His career trajectory from MSU to international construction projects provides a template for professional success that other Mindanao Muslims have followed. Many engineers from Lanao del Sur and Lanao del Norte cite Macadindang's example as proof that geographic and cultural background need not limit professional ambitions.

On a practical level, his overseas work contributed to the positive reputation of Filipino engineers in the Middle East, helping to secure opportunities for subsequent generations of OFWs. His technical competence and professionalism in managing multi-million dollar construction projects reinforced the perception of Filipinos as skilled and reliable workers.

His establishment of Happy Family Hardware and continued work as a supervising engineer demonstrate a commitment to knowledge transfer, ensuring that the expertise gained abroad benefits the Philippine construction industry. By remaining professionally active after retirement, he continues to mentor younger engineers and contribute to infrastructure development in his home country.

Recognition and Significance

While formal awards and honors are not extensively documented, Macadindang's recognition comes primarily from the respect accorded to him within the Meranao engineering community and among Filipino engineers who worked in Saudi Arabia. His name is frequently mentioned in discussions about pioneering Muslim professionals who broke barriers in technical fields during the 1970s and 1980s.

The establishment of Insan Islamic Assembly, Inc. stands as institutional recognition of his leadership within the Muslim community. Being selected as one of four founders indicates the trust and esteem in which he is held by fellow community members.

His continued employment as a supervising engineer for multiple commercial projects in his senior years reflects the confidence that private sector clients place in his judgment and expertise, a form of professional recognition that speaks to decades of proven competence.

Challenges and Context

Macadindang's achievements must be understood against the backdrop of significant challenges faced by Muslim Filipinos in the 1970s. The period of his board exam was marked by the escalation of the Moro conflict in Mindanao, the declaration of Martial Law in 1972, and widespread displacement of Muslim communities. Pursuing higher education and professional certification during this turbulent period required extraordinary focus and resilience.

As a Muslim engineer working in the Philippines during the late 1970s and early 1980s, Macadindang likely encountered both subtle and overt forms of discrimination. The decision to work overseas in 1982 may have been driven partly by limited opportunities for Muslim professionals in the Philippine private sector and government, where Christian Filipinos dominated executive and technical positions.

His work in Saudi Arabia, while professionally rewarding, came with the typical challenges faced by OFWs, including family separation, adaptation to different cultural norms, and the vulnerability of being a foreign worker in a kafala system that often favored employers over employees. Despite these challenges, Macadindang persevered and achieved success, demonstrating the adaptability and work ethic for which Filipino OFWs are renowned.

See Also

- Mindanao State University
- Meranao people
- Civil engineering in the Philippines
- Filipino engineers in the Middle East
- Overseas Filipino Workers

External Links

- Profile provided by Nisa Moslem Macadindang-Benasing (https://www.facebook.com/nismm03)

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